

The VU Research School: A Discussion Paper

1. Strategic Context and Purpose

Victoria University's Strategic Plan (2016-2020) articulates a vision for being the University of Opportunity and Success by being open and excellent, creating exceptional value for any student from any background and uplifting the communities in which we operate¹. To achieve this vision, VU has two complementary priorities: i. to provide high quality, standards-based education through engaging, industry relevant curricula and enhanced approaches to student success and ii. to engage in high quality, innovative applied and translational research that results in healthier, smarter and sustainable communities in the west of Melbourne and beyond, connecting deeply with industry and the community and, in turn, enhancing the quality of teaching and learning and its scholarship.

In December 2016 the Vice-Chancellor introduced the VU Student Success concept. This has resulted in the development of the transformative VU First Year Model, which forms the cornerstone for a systemic approach to enhancing the quality of our students' learning experiences and outcomes.

This strategic directions paper complements the VU Student Success initiative by proposing the establishment of a VU Research School which will have a university-wide approach for enhancing the quality and impact of research and research training at VU.

Consistent with the VU Strategic Plan (Element 1), this proposal is informed by our deeply held commitment to focus on research with impact that delivers productive outcomes to industry and community and enhances teaching and learning, especially in our flagship areas. As outlined in the accompanying draft *Research Plan (2017-2020)*, our vision is for VU to be renowned for research excellence in *Sport, Health and Active Living* and *Sustainable Industries and Liveable Cities*. We will be a preferred collaborator for industry, government and community in these areas, sought after to co-innovate responses to contemporary challenges and opportunities. A vibrant research culture, underpinned by excellence, integrity and engagement, will attract and retain exceptional staff, outstanding students and strategic partners.

This proposal represents the pursuit of a transformational agenda to deliver on this vision by: investing in applied and translational research that has measurable impact (VU Strategic Plan Element 2) and by ensuring financial sustainability (VU Strategic Plan Element 3) through increased productivity characterised by the pursuit of focused research and research training, strategic redirection and allocation of academic effort, and an ongoing emphasis on strong financial management in relation to research and research training².

VU is resolute in its focus on educational and research activities that are standards-based and characterised by the highest quality. In harmony with the national Higher Education Standards Framework (2015) and associated Guidance Notes³, this strategic directions paper therefore reinforces VU's enterprise-wide regard for scholarship, which includes those activities concerned with gaining new or improved understanding, appreciation and insights into a field of knowledge, and engaging with and keeping up to date with advances in the field. This includes advances in ways of teaching and learning in the field and advances in professional practice, as well as advances in disciplinary knowledge through original research. At the core of our work this means making a contribution to and maintaining knowledge of current and emerging developments in a field of research (i.e. a research discipline), and transmission of this knowledge to academic, industry and community groups as well as through effective, contemporary approaches to teaching and learning. To better position VU as an outward facing, industry and community engaged leader in research and research training nationally and internationally, the organisational structure and functions around research and research training must be fit for purpose and enable VU to pioneer advances in its key areas of focus and strength.

¹ See 'Victoria University: The University of Opportunity and Success – Strategic Plan 2016-2020'.

² The VU Council requires a break-even financial result in 2018. Prior to the recent announcement (May 2017) by the Federal Minister of an efficiency dividend being required in 2018 and 2019, our most up-to-date assessment of the improvement needed in our net result, to break even in 2018, is \$45.5million.

³ See (a) The Higher Education Standards Framework (Threshold Standards) 2015 parts A and B, effective from 1 January 2017, and with particular reference to part B1.2 'Australian University' category (TS 2015); (b) TEQSA Guidance Note: Scholarship, updated at 13 December 2016 (GN 13 December 2016); (c) TEQSA Guidance Note: Research and Research Training, at 21 October 2016 (GN 21 October 2016).

This discussion paper presents a proposition for a Research Model to unify and strengthen the quality and sustainability of research and research training activity at VU. It is complemented by the Draft VU Research Plan (2017-2020), which outlines in further detail the research vision, strategic goals and proposed key initiatives for the next triennium.

2. Propositions: in summary

Propositions for enhancing the quality and sustainability of research and research training at VU are as follows:

- i. to consolidate, align and focus research and research training to achieve the University's strategic plans, educational priorities and financial necessities
- ii. to anchor research and research training within the broader notion of scholarship, as conceptualised by TEQSA (see Footnote 3)
- iii. to maximise the University's research and research training performance and available funding by sharpening research focus and improving efficiency.

Headline proposed changes would be to:

- i. create a consolidated VU Research School to oversee and administer *all* research activity, including *all* research training (HDR) activity
- ii. budget explicitly for a global research allocation and from student revenue, allocate all HDR revenue to HDR activity and, on these bases, require both research and research training to be break-even activities
- iii. contribute approximately \$10 million per annum of expenditure savings to the University budget based on the 2016 actual financial performance.

3. Propositions: in detail

The following propositions relate to potential structural changes to enhance the way in which VU manages research and research training in the context of the reforms already underway in the academy. Any organisational and process change would be subject to discussion and consultation according to clause 66 of the *Victoria University Enterprise Agreement 2013*.

3.1 Structural and process propositions relating to research activities for 2018

- i. Allocate 8% of CSP-funded revenue to research⁴.
 - In 2017 the allocation would equate to approximately \$16 million.
- ii. Create a consolidated research entity (e.g. VU Research School) to house all of the University's research activity, including research institutes and centres, research time of academic staff and the research management functions of the research and research training portfolio.
 - The VU Research School would receive all research revenue and the proposed 8% allocation of CSP-funded revenue. On this basis, it would be expected to: (a) balance its budget and (b) allocate its expenses between research institutes and centres, the research allocation time of academic staff, together with administrative and support functions to maximise performance.
- iii. Be focussed, intentional and strategic in determining allocation of funds to prioritised research investment areas (i.e. Fields of Research) and organise structures and processes accordingly.

⁴ This figure reflects CSP revenue for undergraduate and relevant postgraduate coursework offerings at VU.

- It is proposed that in the first instance, the Research and Research Training portfolio and the Academic Workforce Futures office will collaborate with College Deans and their leadership teams to identify the fields of research that the University will value and prioritise from 2018 and which following further consultation within the University, will inform future research effort and research time allocated to academic staff.
- It is proposed that from 2018 academic staff research time would be budgeted strategically and 'bought out'⁵ from Colleges by the proposed VU Research School. Compared with the 2016 performance, these changes would create a budget saving of about \$8 million in 2018.

3.2 Structural and process propositions relating to higher degree by research (HDR) training for 2018

It is proposed to:

- Allocate all research-training (HDR) revenue to research training.
 - In 2016 this was about \$7.1 million, which we assume will be similar for 2018. This would end the current budget practice of taking a contribution to University overheads from HDR revenue and then, in effect, reallocating support for HDR supervision and management.
- House all of the University's HDR activity within the VU Research School: student supervision time allocated to academic staff and research-only academic supervisors and the HDR functions of the research and research-training portfolio.
 - Allocate all research-training (HDR) revenue to the VU Research School.
 - On this basis, the VU Research School would be expected to: (a) balance its budget and (b) allocate its expenses so as to maximise performance.

The University budget saving arising from the propositions outlined in 3.2 would be about \$2 million in 2018 compared to 2016 performance.

4. Proposed next steps

As is appropriate for such a proposition, and as is required by our Enterprise Agreement, this strategic directions discussion paper will form the basis for preliminary discussions with VU staff, the NTEU and students. This will provide the opportunity to have conversations and exchange ideas about the propositions before making a definitive decision and moving to a more formal change process. This preliminary discussion phase will also provide an opportunity for more detailed consideration of the potential implications for staff and the value proposition for HDR students.

Companion document: *Draft VU Research Plan (2017-2020): Shaping healthier, smarter and more sustainable communities*. Available online [here](#).

Prepared by:

⁵ 'Buying out' time of academic staff from Colleges, thus reducing their availability to a College, is common practice, e.g. this currently applies to first-year champions ('bought out' with HEPPP funding), blended learning coordinators ('bought out' with University strategic funding), cross-appointments to research institutes and centres (e.g. ISEAL) and so on.

Professor Warren Payne, Pro Vice-Chancellor Research and Research Training
Professor Kerri-Lee Krause, Deputy Vice-Chancellor and Provost⁶

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